

Cuphead Show, *Dota: Dragon's Blood*, *Dragon Age: Absolution*, and the game-changing *Arcane*. So, what have they been doing right?

C'mon folks, we've been through this

Within our lifetime, we've seen western media struggle with adaptations. The early filmmakers' attempts at bringing comic books to the big screen were hilarious, if at all well-intentioned. While Jon Favreau finally broke the barrier for Marvel in 2008 with *Iron Man*, it's usually Sam Raimi, Tim Burton and Christopher Nolan who are credited as the original tri-fecta that set the stage for modern day comic book adaptations.

All three directors took very different approaches to the genre. Raimi worked as close to the source material as possible, dealing with it in the most straightforward manner. Tim Burton took to the stage with the first two Batman movies, going with the Shakespearean approach. Nolan's treatment of the caped crusader, however, was the most memorable – stripped the hero down to his core elements, reconstructing Bruce Wayne's origin story, then locking it all down with everything Batman. While there may be severe opposition from the geek community regarding which of the three did a better job, I think geeks can begrudgingly agree that all three franchises were immensely memorable in their own right.

So if, after 30 years, the film industry is still struggling with the idea of live-action video game adaptations, there are a few case studies to refer to. A good place to start would be to remove gameplay and mechanics from the equation, and then see what you have to work with.

With great power...

Another good idea would be to pick the right showrunner for your adaptation. Case in point, Netflix picked Warren Ellis to take the lead on *Castlevania*. The man's got a reputation for

Adaptation 101



There are a few basic things to keep in mind when looking at adapting anything to film. If most filmmakers kept these in mind when working on screenplays, it may lead to more successful projects.

■ Disregard all preconceptions.

Sometimes, starting from scratch is the best way forward.

■ Play to your strengths.

Creatations are an extension of who you are as a person. Don't aim for fan service. People can tell when the movie you're making isn't genuine.

■ Remember your source material, but don't be bound by it.

This may be easier when dealing with video games that aren't very story-rich; and especially tough when you're looking at a lore-rich universe like *Mass Effect* or *Fallout*.

■ Above all else: tell a story.

Never lose sight of the fact that you need to be a storyteller.

good storytelling, and considering the video game franchise played it fast and loose with lore, he had a fairly blank canvas to work with. Even in the case of *Arcane*, the show had a nine-person writers room, each with a plethora of video-game writing to their names – a fact that clearly translated to screen.

Going as far back as the *Super Mario Bros.* movie, one of the writers on the screenplay was Ed Solomon, known for some of the most memorable cult

classics in geek film history, like the Bill & Ted Trilogy and *Men in Black*. Similarly, the writer combo of Dan Hernandez and Benji Samit were successful adapting the animated show *The Tick* into live action, and were brought on board the team that created *Pokémon: Detective Pikachu*.

So tl;dr: it always helps to know the right person for the job.

The kids are alright

Some of the shows that have come out in the last five or six years (unlike their predecessors) have completely dropped the "made for kids" approach, pushing the content for more mature audiences, much to overall viewer appreciation. From the bloody vampiric theme of *Castlevania* to the mercurial underbelly of human nature portrayed in *Arcane*; even the *Angry Birds Movie*, *Pokémon: Detective Pikachu* and *Ratchet & Clank* pushed humour into 18+ territory.

Back to the Future

Studios have now picked up on positive feedback of video game-based television shows, and there's an exciting number of franchises being adapted at the moment. AMC has picked up *Alan Wake*; Prime Video plans to make OTT shows based on *Warhammer*, *God of War*, *Fallout* and *Mass Effect*; and to say nothing of the plethora of games like *Bioshock*, *Elder Scrolls* and *Devil May Cry* being adapted for streaming by Netflix.

The long and short of it is audio-visual media seems to have finally bypassed the guillotine that's been butchering video game franchises for decades. Then again, if there's

anything we've learned from even the more successful franchises out there – there's always a possibility of excrement hitting the rotors.

There's still some hope, though. We think we can safely say that the worst is behind us. *

